How Congress Talks About AI

A Data-Driven Analysis of 192 Congressional Hearings

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The Big Picture

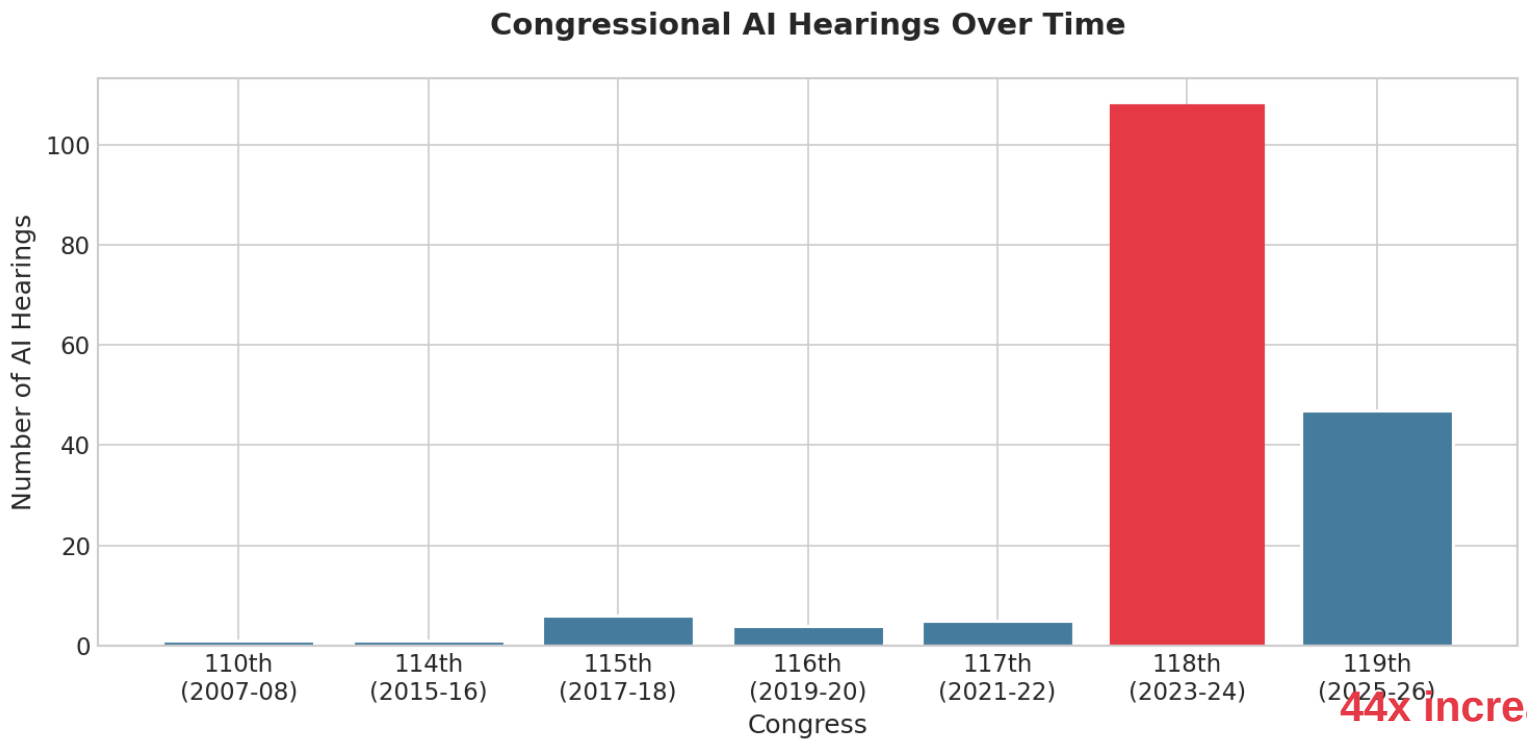
Congress frames AI as a race to win, not a technology to govern.

National Security + Economic Opportunity = 43% of hearings

Risk + Rights = 35% of hearings

192	90%	κ=0.66
Hearings Analyzed	Post-ChatGPT (2023-2026)	Inter-Rater Reliability

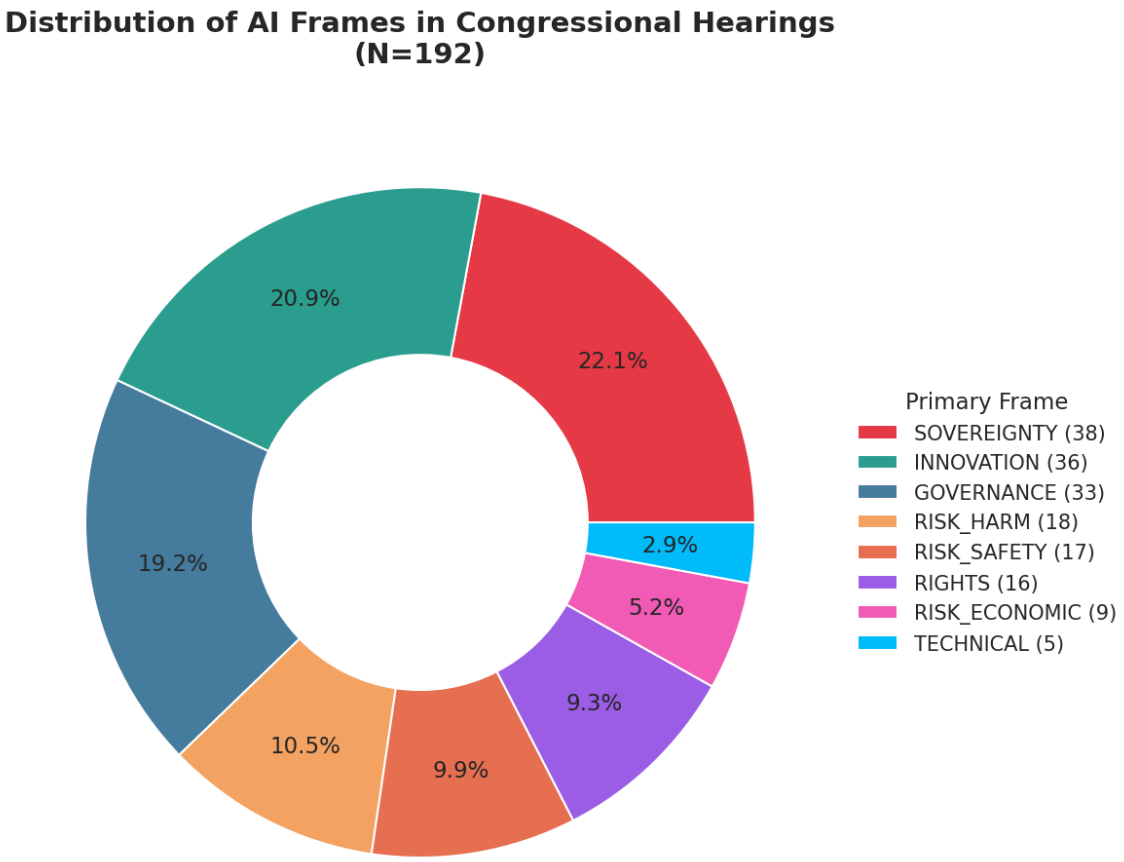
AI Attention Exploded After ChatGPT



44x increase

in AI hearings post-2022

How AI is Framed in Congress



Top 3 Frames (62%)

■ Sovereignty: 22%

China competition

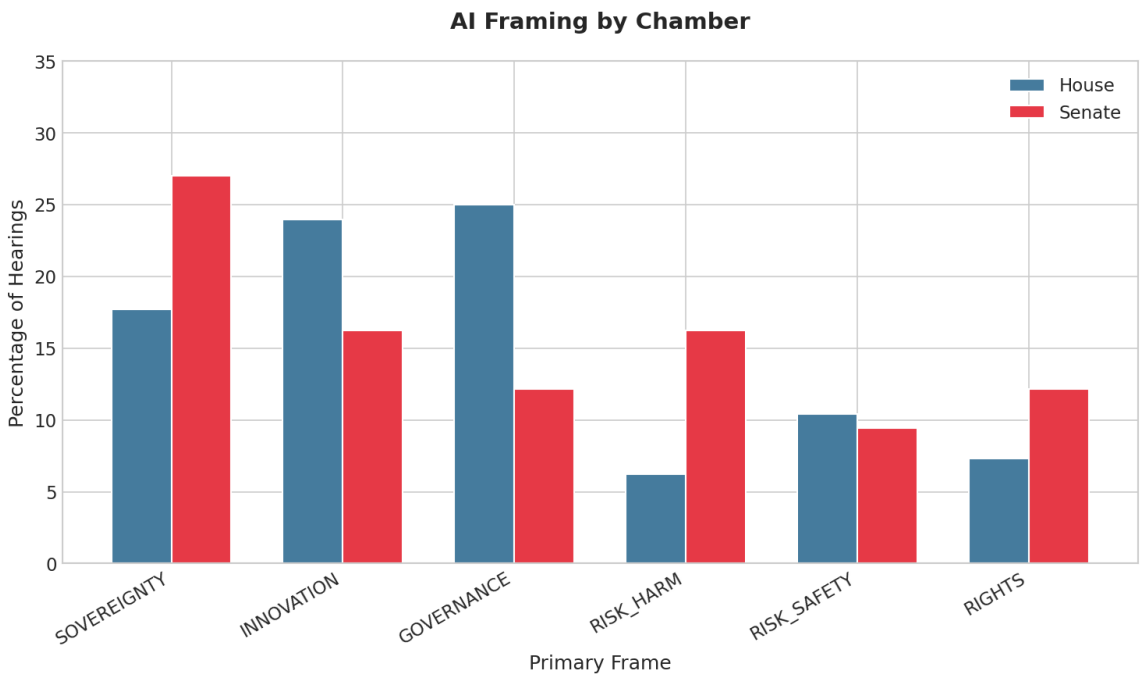
■ Innovation: 21%

Economic opportunity

■ Governance: 19%

Regulatory frameworks

Senate vs House: Different Priorities



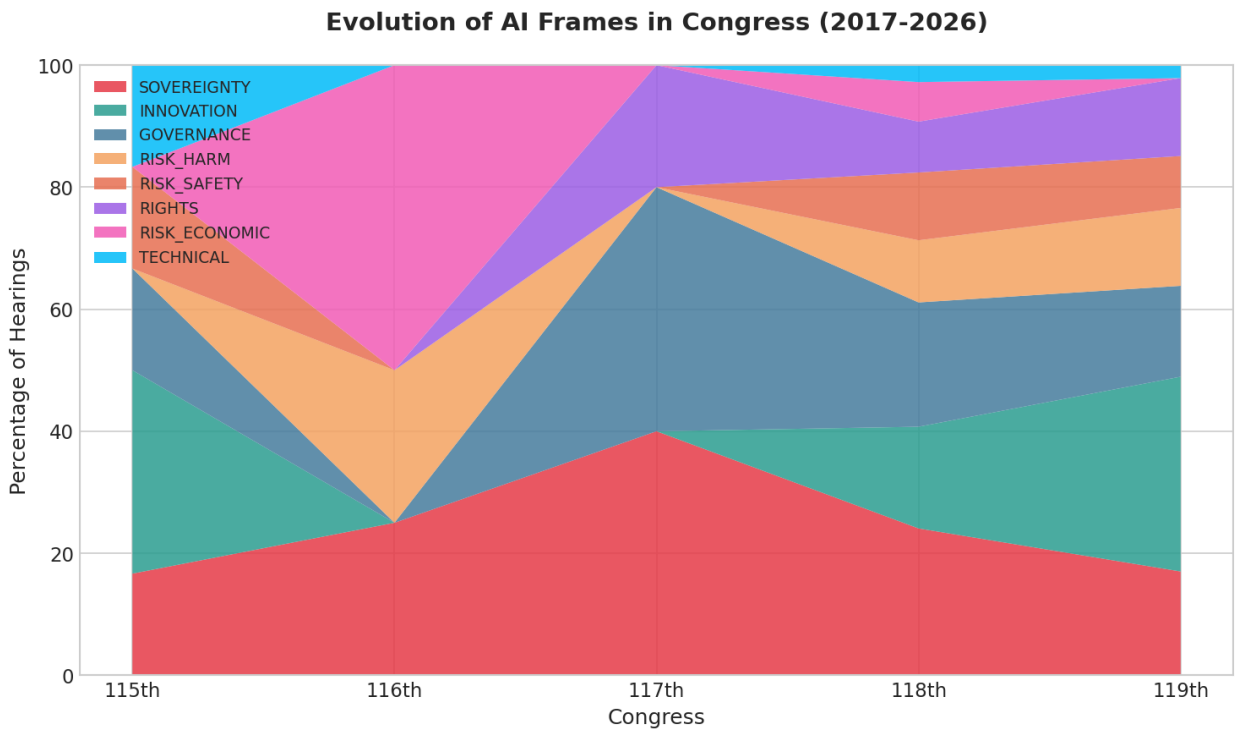
Key Differences:

- Senate: +55% more Sovereignty
- House: +53% more Innovation
- Senate: +67% more Risk/Harm

Senate → Security focus

House → Economic focus

Frames Evolved Over Time



Key Trend:

RIGHTS frame

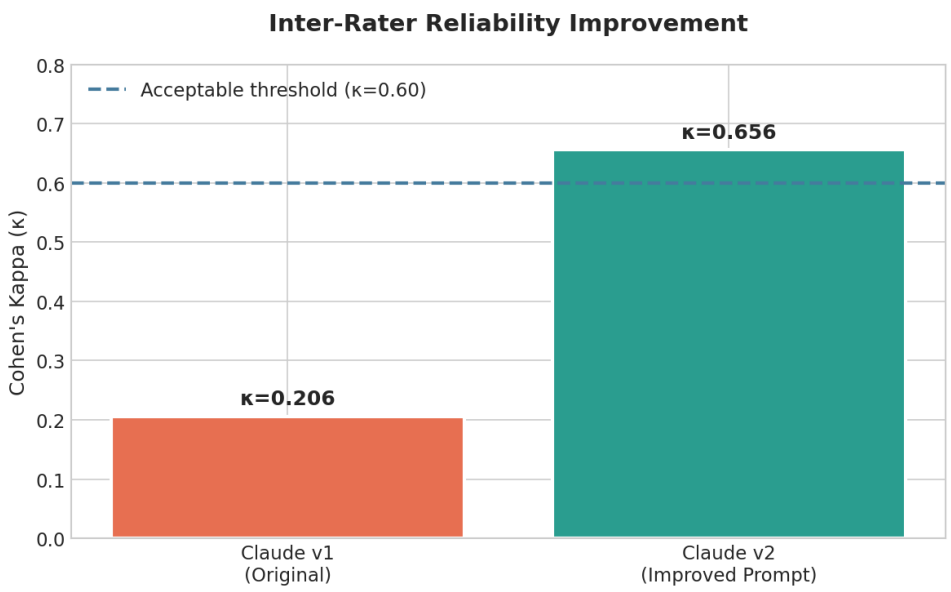
only appeared in

118th Congress (2023)

Civil liberties concerns

were late to the debate

Methodology: Multi-Model AI Coding



Approach:

- 2 LLM coders (Kimi + Claude)
- CommDAAF framework
- Full transcript analysis

Prompt Engineering:

- v1: κ=0.206 (over-coded)
- v2: κ=0.656 ✓

Lesson: Instruction clarity dramatically affects reliability

What This Means for Policy

■ Expect Support For:

- AI R&D investment
- Talent pipelines & immigration
- Export controls on adversaries
- Defense AI applications

■■ Limited Momentum For:

- Comprehensive AI safety rules
- Algorithmic accountability
- Privacy protections
- Worker displacement support

The framing battle shapes the policy battle.

Stakeholders must engage dominant frames or work to elevate alternatives.

Thank You

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Data, code, and papers available upon request